LEADERSHIP TRANSITIONS IN UNIVERSITIES

Arriving, Surviving and Thriving at the Top

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9 Leading change

From ‘launch pad’ to ‘lift-off’

If you are trying to drive increasing levels of engagement and change and culture change, I think you have got to be visible and visibly leading.

You can’t do anything as an HoU unless you’ve got a board which supports you.

Introduction

Your success as a head of university (HoU) is not going to be judged on the basis of the quality of your strategy, the glossy document you publish, the impressive accompanying website or the PowerPoint presentation that your team have put together for launch day, although each of these may be useful. Sometimes, once the strategy document has been produced, presented to the governing body, broadly accepted by the university community and ‘formally launched’, the job of an HoU can seem to be done. You can now delegate the delivery of the strategy to your senior team, led by the provost or DVC. Be careful, though: this is usually a big mistake. Your success, or lack thereof, will be judged on the basis of your delivery alone. Can you inspire others to be excited enough to want to contribute to translating the fine words into action? Will you get your strategy beyond the launch pad? Have you got enough thrust behind it to achieve lift-off?

In this chapter, we explore the realities of delivering sustainable change, what this implies and how to strike the right balance between providing strategic oversight and guidance and providing detailed and tactical action. Both are important, and as HoU, you will need to play your part in both arenas. Judging when to shift your focus from one to the other is often critical. We present a leadership framework to help you to scope your ‘portfolio of change’ and ensure delivery. We conclude by considering some other pitfalls to be aware of as you move from the ‘launch pad’ phase to achieving ‘lift-off’.

In recognition of the extraordinary world that we have been living through in 2020, in the next chapter (Chapter 10), we focus on the process of leading change in a world where the COVID-19 pandemic has created a dramatically different context for leadership. What else is required for people to lead change in and through a crisis?

As a link to the next chapter, we conclude this one by asking whether our approach to change during periods of relative stability needs to be supplemented by one better suited to periods of high uncertainty. Does our conception of leading change need to change?

Delivering sustainable change

In the design of your strategy, you need to get engagement across the university – as the two opening quotes to this chapter highlight. However, you must obtain complete and rigorous buy-in from the people around you, particularly the board and the chair, in the delivery of your agenda. With a strong collective mandate for your new strategy (not just a sign-off), the challenge now becomes one of ensuring delivery, particularly during the crucial first three to six months after the launch phase. Different stakeholders will be watching with interest how you perform now. The honeymoon period will have long passed. If you are fortunate, you may have a community keen to 'get on with it', as one of our interviewees described:

> *I actually found when I came that there was a lot of appetite for change. The top-down command-and-control style over that period had demoralised the workforce and they were ready for change. Not everybody. Obviously, there were factions and cliques and people who benefited from the previous regime who were sad to see it go, including one or two members of the executive team, but I think the general sense that I got was that the university was ready for a different kind of leadership*.

In other cases, you might find yourself having to respond to a different context from the one you expected when you accepted the HoU role, as another interviewee explained:

> *I had to make a major structural change within the first six months of being here which, if you'd said to me as vice-chancellor, that's what you would do, I'd say that's definitely not what I'm going to do, but I had to because of the financial position. . . . As part of my first year, we said goodbye to over x staff, but subsequently, I've been able to recruit almost x new academics and given we only have a total population of x academics, we pretty much changed the entire academic community. So, now we've embedded a completely different mindset, and a completely different outlook. Yes, I'm fortunate, although challenging at the time, it was a real opportunity for me which we've used effectively*.

You might be facing a lethargic, or even antagonistic, audience, particularly if you have signalled significant change (and if significant structural change is being called for) or if a significant subgroup in the community has lost interest in

the 'strategy'. If your transition period was a long one from when your successor announced their intention to leave to your arrival, there might have been no clear strategy, giving rise to a situation where individuals or coalitions were disinterested in 'delivery'.

Whatever the situation, you and your senior leadership team need to co-create an agenda for delivery to which they will commit their discretionary time and energy beyond just 'doing their job'. Delivering and making change sustainable, at scale across a university, demand much effort by many people over a significant period of time. Without the energetic support of your senior team, you won't be able to deliver your agenda.

None of this will be new to you. On the way to the top, you will have had considerable experience in leading and delivering successful change. You will doubtless have offered examples to your appointing panel of how you achieved success through your actions and decisions and how you worked with others to make a real difference. From improving student success and outcomes to delivering increases in research outputs and impact and from turning around a failing unit to increasing revenue and surplus and delivering major capital projects, your track record is likely to be impressive enough for you to be appointed. You will likely have given evidence of your ability to develop a strategy and play a significant role in delivering elements of a university-wide strategic plan. This is all valuable, but you now need to play a different role.

Take the following case: over a 12-month period, the university had created a classic document: strategy 20XX (where 'XX' represents 25, 30, 40 or some other number). There was a statement of purpose, a vision, a statement of values, a group of strategic priorities and a suite of success criteria by which it would assess itself in 20XX, including a set of key performance indicators (KPIs). It was all there, so what could possibly be the problem? Several people in the senior leadership team were relatively new, having been appointed during the phase leading up to the creation of the document. Some had a degree of ownership of the overarching strategy, while some had played no role in its formation. Needless to say, 'lift-off' was proving challenging. Breathing life into the delivery process demanded a collective commitment to defining, at a high level, a means by which delivery would be possible. This required working at operational and strategic levels; the characteristics of each are captured in Table 9.1.

Two interviewees cautioned about having expectations on the speed of delivery, pace and nature of change:

> *Anyone who thinks that you can come into a complex institution and change it from day one needs to be careful. You need continuity at times of change. That's key isn't it? I mean continuity of purpose, not necessarily personnel, although sometimes that's important too.*

> *Remember you are but a guardian. And I just worry that you can't let your personal ego get into this, you know, this place existed for a long time before I was here and will continue a long time after I've gone. Whatever you inherit*

Table 9.1 Operational and strategic delivery characteristics

Operational delivery	*Strategic delivery*
Short term (next 12 months)	Longer term (will take at least 5 years to deliver)
Relatively simple	Highly complex
Largely about project managing a portfolio of activities through the normal channels of team members	Will require building a strong and shared internal purpose, ambition and cultural commitment to ensure successful delivery
Can be delivered by deploying or redeploying existing resources	Will require creating a community of influential leaders if it is to be sustained
Projects sit within boundaries of 1 or 2 existing units	More holistic, much more institution-wide in nature
Largely delivered through internal resources with limited external assistance	Will require working with a wide range of external strategic partners
Mostly transactional and mostly process, compliance and system oriented	Has the potential to transform individuals, teams and ultimately the organisation
Can be delivered by using existing project management and planning systems and techniques, typically reporting through existing channels	Demands a highly coordinated 'system-level' approach, which joins the dots of business intelligence, prioritising activities at multiple levels (from portfolios to personnel)
Political sensitivities largely internal	Political sensitivities largely external
Existing metrics and KPIs can be used to monitor progress	Requires new metrics to be developed, to report on progress

> *and however you leave it, I mean, you like to think you'd inherit it in good shape and move it on to be in even better shape.*

To help you to choose your approach and prioritise your actions, we start by exploring the landscape of change and innovation. We then consider some frameworks that may help with the process of delivering sustainable change.

Mapping your landscape of change and innovation

One of the more significant aspects of the change agenda at the HoU level is the many dimensions involved. Daily, you will be engaging in change on multiple issues at many levels, internally and externally, focusing on long-term strategic issues and on more-operational and more tactically significant matters. Without prioritising your agenda, you are likely to find yourself responding and reacting to events rather than being able to control your time and that of others by focusing on the right issues – easy to say but much more difficult to do in practice. So how might you approach this challenge?

Your portfolio of change

The first step, some suggest, is to reframe your role from 'change manager or changemaker' (with the implication that you will be an active participant in the delivery of change) to another frame of reference. One often cited is for you to become 'the architect of change'. In this reframing, your task becomes that of translating the ideas (in the strategy) into an inspiring design, engaging externally with others, building a team of specialists to deliver different parts of your vision, finding fixes when technical problems arise and monitoring progress. The metaphor, while helpful, doesn't completely capture the full range of the role. You might want to add the role of mayor, elected with a mandate to change your city or town. This highlights that you are now being more of a political operator, needing to gain support from your constituents; to represent their hopes, wishes and desires; and to develop your city and promote it to a range of stakeholders. You will probably have to build coalitions with others, make deals and – when critical incidents or crises arise – be the person who is in the spotlight, helping others deal with the aftermath of some event. Above all, you will need many others to find solutions to challenges that do not have easy technical fixes.

The metaphors of 'architect' and 'mayor' may help you to think about the range of change agendas that you will need to oversee, coordinate and ultimately integrate into a coherent portfolio of change. To help HoUs and their senior team to move from launch pad to lift-off, we developed the framework in Figure 9.1, which serves as a reference for undertaking a collective, team-based analysis. Adopting this approach can help ensure that all team members understand who is working on what and with whom, all the interdependencies and where the key pinch points are at any moment in time.

Technical change challenges: *fixing things*

Technical challenges are typically change activities led by members of the senior team. These typically involve deploying capabilities that already exist in the organisation. In one sense, these are the sort of issues that should not demand too much of your attention. But sometimes they do – for good, or less good, reasons.

In at least two ways, technical challenges can pose dangers for HoUs. First, you can be attracted to getting involved in these technical areas, particularly when you have first-hand experience of the challenge. While you recognise the value of delegating the issue to one of your team, you find yourself (even unwittingly) taking a disproportionate amount of interest in the process and outcomes. Your team member, initially, finds this helpful as you understand and give clear guidance on the issues. Over time, however, your desire for routine check-ins on progress begin to feel intrusive; you are shifting into the micromanagement danger zone. Your team member's commitment starts to reduce, and if you are not careful, this spreads to other team members. Alternatively, you assume a 'no news is good news' stance on some technical challenge, only to find yourself surprised when it fails to deliver on time, on budget, or at all. This danger zone may arise in

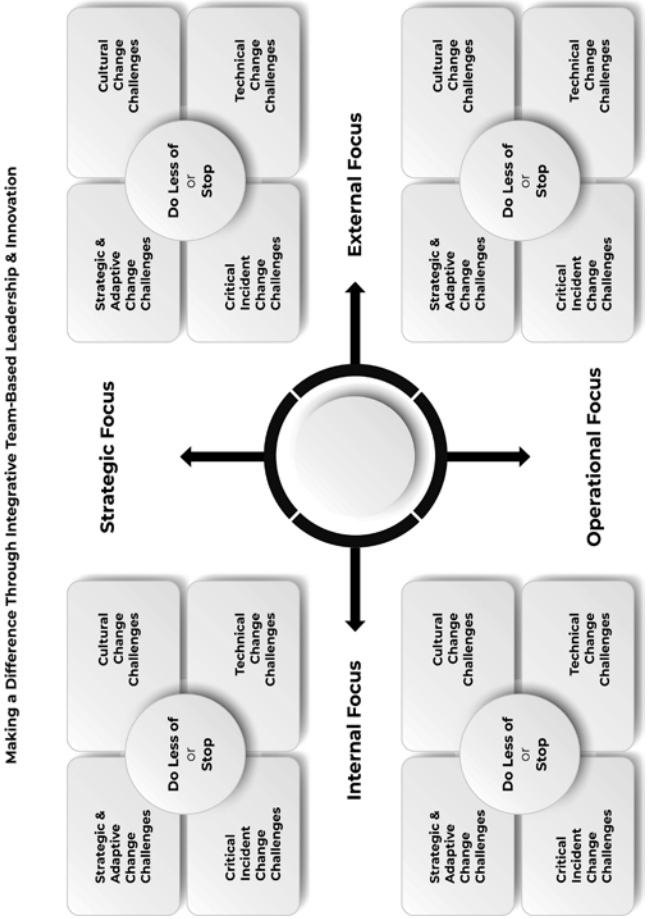

Figure 9.1 Making a difference through integrative team-based leadership and innovation

apparently 'simple' changes, perhaps a project to upgrade an information technology (IT) system, an aspect of the student experience or a restructuring of a part of the university. Too hands-off is as problematic as too hands-on.

Without becoming overly obsessive about the myriad of such 'fixes' underway, you should routinely review progress with the senior team as part of your weekly or twice weekly meetings. The act of taking an interest and asking a question or two offers you an opportunity to sense check how things are progressing (or not).

Strategic and adaptive change challenges: *delivering your promises*

The next suite of change activities is central to delivering the promises in your strategy. These are not the technical elements which, while complex, typically have an end state that is clear and definable. Now you need to deal with the tougher stuff, often referred to as the 'adaptive change challenges', as defined by Heifetz, Grashow and Linsky.[1] These are the change challenges for which there is no easy, or existing, solution within or beyond the organisation. These challenges require people to learn new capabilities and create new solutions.

As Heifetz et al. emphasise,

> *Most problems do not always come neatly packaged as either 'technical' or 'adaptive'. When you take on a new challenge at work, it does not arrive with a big T or A stamped on it. Most problems come mixed, with the technical and adaptive elements intertwined.*

They continue:

> *Adaptive change challenges can only be addressed through changing people's priorities, beliefs, habits and loyalties. New adaptations significantly displace, reregulate, and rearrange some old DNA. By analogy, leadership on adaptive challenges generates loss. Learning is often painful. One person's innovation can cause another person to feel incompetent, betrayed, or irrelevant. Not many people like to be 'rearranged'. Leadership therefore requires the diagnostic ability to recognise those losses and the predictable defensive patterns of response that operate at the individual and systemic level. It also requires knowing how to counteract these patterns.*

To further illustrate the distinction, Heifetz et al. cite the following illustration in a paper titled 'Leadership in a (permanent) crisis'[2]:

> *Consider the heart attack that strikes in the middle of the night.* [The patient] *is rushed to the hospital, where expert trauma and surgical teams – executing established procedures because there is little time for creative improvisation – stabilize the patient and then provide new vessels for the heart.* [This is the technical change challenge.] *The emergency has passed, but a high-stakes, if*

> *somewhat less urgent, set of challenges remains. Having recovered from the surgery, how does the patient prevent another attack? Having survived, how does the patient adapt to the uncertainties of a new reality in order to thrive?* [This is the adaptive change challenge.]

In so many ways, dealing with the more tangible, more predictable and apparently safer technical problems seems easier. However, therein lurks a danger, as Heifetz et al. suggest:

> *The most common cause of failure in leadership is produced by treating adaptive challenges as if they were technical problems*.

You may find yourself wondering why either the approach proposed by your colleagues is simply not working or the approach you used at your previous university is not getting traction here. The time for a change of approach can be difficult to determine but is worth watching out for. Are you really dealing with only a technical change challenge or something different?

A useful application of the framework can be found in a case study by John Raftery, who was then vice-chancellor of London Metropolitan University.[3] His paper focuses on leading a financial and cultural turnaround process over a four-year period (2014–2018). In the paper, he describes how he applied the adaptive leadership framework through four key stages.

1 *Diagnosis – the illusion of a broken system*

Raftery described it as follows:

> *Counterintuitively, the organisation was not broken. It was instead perfectly tuned to achieve the results it was getting. Students were not receiving the best outcomes possible. But staff were. For my very first meeting with any group in the university, and because I believe in the value of unions and had been a member for over 20 years, I chose to meet with the union representatives. I found that they had carved out a share (of university income) for payroll which was 25 per cent bigger than the average, but that their members were delivering around 25 per cent less than average on student outcomes, an 'x-inefficiency' of some 50 per cent. This appeared to be working for their members in the short term, but it was obvious that in the long term they would have no members*.

2 *Interpretation – the song beneath the words*

In this phase, he highlights the following:

> *There is plenty of science of course, but also some art in leadership. A good example of the latter is having the mindfulness to listen attentively to what is* ***not*** *being said and to find meaning which leads to actionable insight. Standing on the balcony and observing the dynamics below, the key question is,*

what is really going on here? Some 2000 people had jobs and had become accustomed to low expectations of standards of work from themselves and their students. The dominant narrative I encountered was that of poor leadership, of being a 'victim' of events and that external forces were somehow hostile.

(our emphasis, in boldface)

3 *Intervention – we write our script*

In this phase, Raftery foregrounds the principles of the adaptive leadership framework, by emphasising the following:

We needed to go beyond short-term technical fixes and bring about adaptive change. My intention, outlined in the Strategic Plan which we published in 2015, was not merely to fix a range of problems, but to build an organisation that routinely identifies and fixes its problems, an organisation that learns to regenerate and adapt to change through building its own adaptive leadership capacity.

Encountering a lot of upward delegation, it became crucial to ripen some issues, educate staff about long-term consequences of current behaviours (with oft-repeated messages from me such as 'this organisation will not survive a third crisis'), then give the university community a high-level of agency in developing and implementing solutions.

4 *Building an adaptive culture – to make the change sustainable*

The paper also emphasises the importance of building an adaptive culture:

This is a long-term project, but we have made good progress. 'Elephants' (as I write, further improvements are needed to address drop-out rates, which are improving but too slowly) are routinely named, responsibility is shared and interventions are designed from the ground up, often involving large numbers of staff and students. The organisation regenerates itself through maintaining some focus on experiment, innovation and developing its leadership capacities while also running its 'business as usual'.

The paper concludes with some persuasive evidence of progress in a context of considerable uncertainty and challenge. Having passed the baton to his successor, we hope that the long-term effects of this significant intervention can be sustained.

Cultural change challenges: *living your values*

Often linked to and part of sustaining an adaptive change challenge (as we saw earlier) is bringing change to elements of the prevailing organisational culture. Doing so requires a more values-based approach involving new ways of working which will challenge prevailing norms and behaviours. Culture change is far from easy. Dangers can arise in (at least) two areas. The first is about emphasising the importance of culture and values in ways that illustrate sincerity and

authenticity and that are not superficial, self-seeking or outsourced. All sorts of problems arise:

- University response perceived as a single-issue matter, or as being about 'fixing' a perceived problem
- An association with expected improvements in survey results through one metric only
- Issues about ownership of the agenda
- Issues about imposing a single or quick 'solution'
- The signals sent about the relative importance of the agenda (an easy fix versus a serious and deeply engaged approach)
- Compounding the problem by fronting it through human resources (HR) or casting it as an agenda led by 'organisational development' (OD) rather than demonstrating visible leadership from the HoU and other senior leaders

Beware of such superficial responses.

A second danger lies in a statement from the HoU about the cultural challenges where the university community has played no part in identifying or acknowledging their existence. This can be compounded by articulated views from senior leaders about 'resistance to change'. A plea from the top for 'less resistance' is highly likely to have the opposite effect, further alienating those in the university community who position themselves against the changes being promoted. In a recent study among presidents of US universities, the second of five most-cited frustrations (for them) was 'faculty resistance to change'. We wonder what their counterparts in the UK and Australia might cite as the top-five frustrations encountered during their tenure. No doubt the first (never enough money) would be similar; it is perhaps a universal 'truth' in universities. The other three – lack of time to reflect; problems inherited from previous leadership; and belief held by others that presidents are infinitely accessible by email for meetings – may also ring true for many. But what about 'faculty resistance to change'?

While we have some sympathy with these US presidents of universities as their role evolves from 'steward to change maker'[4]), we also believe that it is worth reframing 'faculty behaviour' in a different way. According to Heifetz et al.,

> *What people resist is not change per se, but loss. When change involves real or potential loss, people hold on to what they have and resist the change. We suggest that the common factor generating adaptive failure is resistance to loss. A key to leadership, then, is the diagnostic capacity to find out the kinds of losses at stake in a changing situation . . . assessing, managing, distributing, and providing contexts for losses that move people through those losses to a new place.*

Before discounting the 'resisters', consider whether you have communicated sufficiently why the particular and overall portfolio of changes are required. Have you adequately balanced these by highlighting areas of opportunity? Have you

and colleagues considered and worked through the period of transition? How can changes be phased to limit their impact? Simon Sinek's clear articulation of timelines in 'Start with Why'[5] is a timely reminder that the why should be central, followed by the what and then the how aspects of change.

Katzenbach et al.[6] offer further helpful guidance in recognising the deep-seated nature of culture and the difficulties of changing culture. They emphasise the importance of playing to the most positive aspects of the organisation so as to work with and within the culture rather than against it:

> *First observe the behaviour prevalent in your organisation now, and imagine how people would act if your organisation were at its best, especially if their behaviour supported your ambitions. Ask the people in your leadership groups, 'If we had the kind of culture we aspire to, in pursuit of the strategy we have chosen, what kinds of new behaviours would be common? And what ingrained behaviours would be gone?'*

A conversation of this kind needs to be prompted and orchestrated by senior and mid-level leaders. The symbolism of this is significant, and the subsequent distillation of the outcomes is more likely to capture the views that emerge and to describe them in the most culturally appropriate language. If the process can also be expanded into a conversation about the types of behaviours that would serve the university well at its best, this will also help translate the abstract values into more meaningful and more tangible ways of working. We are increasingly sceptical about the overuse of 'values' in university strategies and plans. Conceptually, they are important, but they can become meaningless statements or get lost because of their expansive coverage so that few people can remember them, let alone model them in practice. Where fewer particularly significant values, aligned with a strategy or university mission, have been taken further and translated into 'values in action', results can be more productive. As one of our colleagues commented somewhat caustically,

> *Values need to be lived, not laminated.*

Critical incident change challenges: *stuff will happen*

Critical incidents are unexpected events that appear to have arisen out of nowhere. They will also demand your attention. 'Events' are not new to you, as a senior leader. What is new is that you are now on the front line in relation to small events that spiral and big events that affect the whole institution. In either case, you will need to speak on behalf of the university, being clearly present in your HoU role.

Most critical incidents and mini-crises will be out of your sight, dealt with by your team, mostly without your knowledge. There is no point in troubling yourself with these – you have enough to deal with. By the time they escalate to your level, they will have been through some form of sifting and preassessment; a proposed solution may well have been worked out; and as an HoU, you will want to

have a conversation to clarify the timing and sequencing of actions, making sure that the tone of the message is right. Most weeks, at least one of these is likely to reach your desk. These are difficult but 'relatively' straightforward to deal with.

A different type of critical incident is one that has an immediate and significant impact on one or many people in the organisation: the death of a student or member of staff, a major accident or terrorist attack involving students or staff members travelling outside the country, a demonstration or occupation of part of the university, a flood, a localised fire, an outbreak of some medical condition requiring the evacuation of part of the university or some breaking news about issues where a statement is required from you. All these examples have one common feature: the need for your visibility and voice. These cannot be delegated to others. This is easy to say but tough to do. Yet at these times, as the leader of the organisation, you must (to paraphrase Heifetz et al.) 'get on the balcony' and make your voice heard. A public statement will also doubtless be required, but without your visible presence, it will be viewed as merely empty words.

A further type of event is large-scale and classed as a 'major incident'. For such major incidents, your internal critical incident policy will be required and tested. En route to the top, you may have gained first-hand experience of such an event, through a real or hypothetical scenario to test your policy. Of course, you can expect your registrar/university secretary/chief operating officer (COO) to be fully familiar with this policy and associated actions. However, you are legally the 'accountable officer', so the agenda is particularly important to you. Your performance in this arena will be judged by your governing body, external stakeholders and the wider community.

You will need to understand the links between critical incident planning and business continuity planning. Whatever your experience was before taking up office, you should consider when to test the collective capacity of your senior team to respond to a major incident. The Universities and Colleges Information Systems Association (UCISA) Guidelines on Approaches to Business Continuity, 2019,[7] offer some useful guidance on designing a developmental event of this type.

If the thought of this additional call on your schedule feels unnecessary, please reflect on the rare but nevertheless tragic impact of major incidents. Glasgow School of Art (GSA) experienced major fire damage to buildings on its campus on two separate occasions in 2014 and 2018 and is a case worth reviewing. The impact of the fires was extreme. Nevertheless, the school managed to respond and recover quickly. You might wish to assess what issues are or should be on your critical incident and business continuity register. What needs to be done to build the organisational resilience necessary to respond to these types of events?

Another type of incident is one that is not obviously critical at the outset. You may have been aware of one of these but had placed it in the 'under investigation' or 'work in progress' category. Most likely, this was a technical issue that you understood was being dealt with by a member of your team. Unexpectedly, the issue escalates and you find yourself having to respond, on short notice and without any detailed background, to an unhappy, angry individual or group. Such

incidents will test your personal resilience, and being prepared will help. You will need to listen, avoid defensiveness and respond authentically.

Critical incidents can also be opportunities; as the old adage goes, 'never let a good crisis go to waste'. Will the novel coronavirus crisis lead some universities to reconsider their internationalisation strategies, their approaches to teaching and learning or their student residence portfolio? The crisis could offer real opportunities to accelerate change and innovation already in the pipeline or stimulate entirely new ways of working and learning. Events such as the COVID-19 pandemic move us well beyond the notion of a critical incident to a full-blown crisis. This requires further dimensions of leadership, a topic we turn to in Chapter 10.

Do less of or stop: *creating headroom*

To do justice to your change agenda, you need time and resources. Even in circumstances when you have inherited or created adequate funds (and perhaps don't see the need for change or innovation), don't avoid these domains; use some funding on this dimension of your agenda. Not everything you are currently doing remains completely relevant. What could you do to reduce or stop working in areas that are no longer directly useful for your new agenda? Addressing such questions is a key component of an agenda for change and innovation and will help you create some headroom and time that can then be deployed on your crucial activities. Creating headroom will also help you avoid the trap of trying to deliver on too many fronts where some of your important issues fall by the wayside.

For some HoUs, the process of making a difference (and bringing in associated changes) involves shaping and influencing an issue which matters deeply and personally. Making sure these are closely linked to your strategy is critical. Guard against 'vanity' projects (yours or others), where the link is not clear.

Your change landscape is complex to oversee and coordinate and will need cumulative action over time. If undertaken well, you will have space to trial new ideas.

Innovation at the interfaces: *finding opportunities to experiment*

Across all areas of your landscape of change, you need to identify where you can start to test, trial, experiment with and explore a few small, or more radical, innovative 'game changer' ideas. These areas for innovation are often those that sit at the interfaces of several portfolios.

Too often, innovation in universities is viewed as an extension of the research agenda, perhaps through translation or the commercialisation of research. This is, of course, a major focus for many universities. However, in many other areas, innovation in a broader sense is required. If we conceive of innovation as the application of creativity to produce an outcome that is new or better or that adds additional value, then the landscape for innovation can be made much broader and

deeper. The opportunities for innovation clearly exist within the core domains of research, teaching and learning, and external engagement. They also arise, however, in the interfaces between these activities in a series of innovation zones, as outlined in Figure 9.2.

From this broader perspective, innovation can be looked at through a range of lenses.

- *Technology-led innovation*: where you want to extend and enhance the use of technology in part or across the whole university. You may want more technology-led innovation, but where, how much, over what time horizon and at what cost?
- *Operational and process innovation*: your focus through this lens might be about simplifying and improving efficiencies in key areas linked to your strategy. For example, increasing your speed of response to student enquiries, particularly those students from overseas, or simplifying and increasing the efficiency of your transactional services, improving your ability to track your response to environmental sustainability or enabling students to navigate their experience, both on campus and digitally.

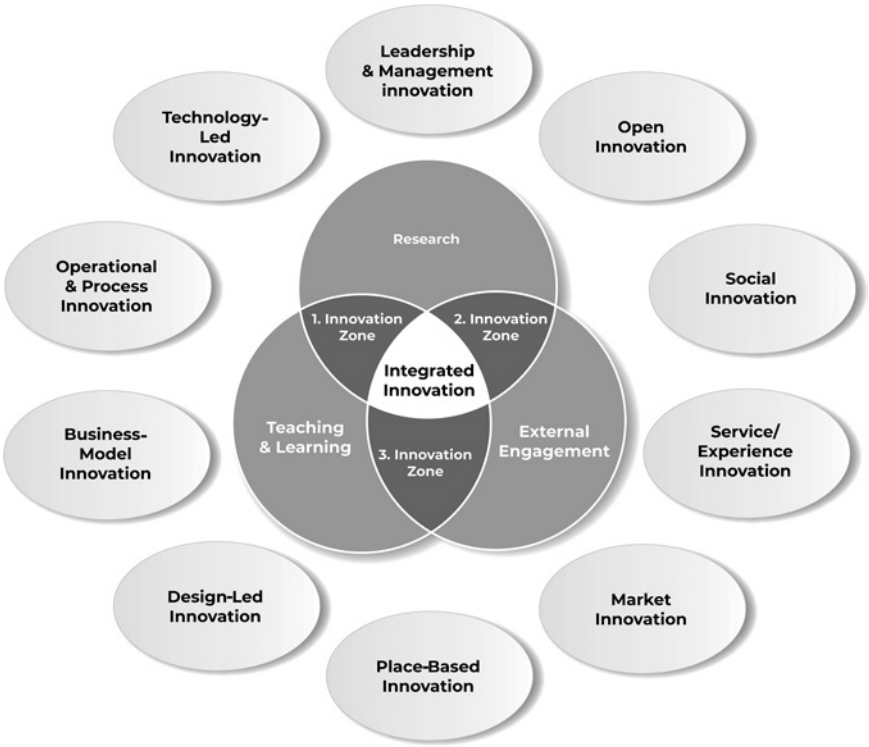

Figure 9.2 Interfaces in a series of innovation zones

- *Business model innovation*: as financial margins are squeezed, the importance of finding new funds increases. To achieve this, innovative thinking in relation to your business model intensifies. Where are new funding sources to be found – through more collaborative ventures and shared services or with public–private partnerships?
- *Design-led innovation*: in this zone, you may wish to expand your emphasis on new or different approaches to using space to enhance the experience of your students and to increasing the level of informal interaction between different areas of the university.
- *Place-based innovation*: where do you see the opportunity to contribute to and convene conversations about the role of the university in contributing to and, in some areas, leading innovation across a city or other region?
- *Market innovation*: how dependent are you on specific disciplines or market areas? How do you diversify your international student population (if you have a significant number) from an overreliance on one or two major countries (typically China and India)?
- *Service/experience innovation*: do you need any further innovation in the student and staff experience as it relates to service excellence?
- *Social innovation*: could you do more to find areas of social engagement and innovation that enhance your contribution to your locality while also strengthening the university?
- *Open innovation*: how do you collaborate with others and use innovative approaches from other organisational settings to assist the university?
- *Leadership and management innovation*: last but by no means least, how do you pay attention to innovative approaches to leadership and management? Are you adequately questioning and challenging conventional organisational wisdom to find new or different ways to operate? To what extent does the existing leadership culture foster, encourage and enable innovation (or hinder it) in all the many forms that we outlined earlier?

Once you have considered your overall portfolio of change, you can ask some further questions:

- What is the balance of activities across your portfolio?
- Is that balance about right, too operational, too strategic, too internal or too external?
- Do you have adequate capacity to deliver the primary technical change challenges?
- Have you been clear about who is leading on these and who is coordinating these challenges across the university?
- Are you clear what the main adaptive change challenges are? Have you assessed the extent to which these are 'ripe'? How are you building the leadership capacity to enable you to address them?
- On what should you focus your attention towards culture change?
- What are your (limited number of) more-radical areas where you wish to test out some innovative thinking and action?

- Have you been clear with the board chair/chancellor about the agenda and gained their insights and support for the most contentious, ambitious or risky elements?
- Have you listened carefully to the views of the board and responded in a manner which recognises their role?

Making a difference: *integrative team-based leadership and innovation*

Having mapped out your landscape and identified your team priorities for change and innovation, you will be looking for individuals and groups who are willing to contribute to the 'team of teams' and who will translate your collective ideas into action. These individuals and groups may be obvious. The challenge is how to gain access to some of their valuable time in order to work on 'our' agenda, rather than the project's being viewed as 'your' agenda for change.

In circumstances when you have set out a radical agenda for change with the potential for significant transformative impact, the need for coordinated action over time becomes even more important. In a study by McKinsey (2015)[8] of a range of organisations aiming to deliver a transformative outcome, the researchers identified a group of actions that leaders needed to ensure happened if they were to increase the likely success of a major transformative change agenda. Figure 9.3 summarises the results.

Among many useful insights from this study is the evidence of having to make progress across a range of different areas and wide range of actions – at least

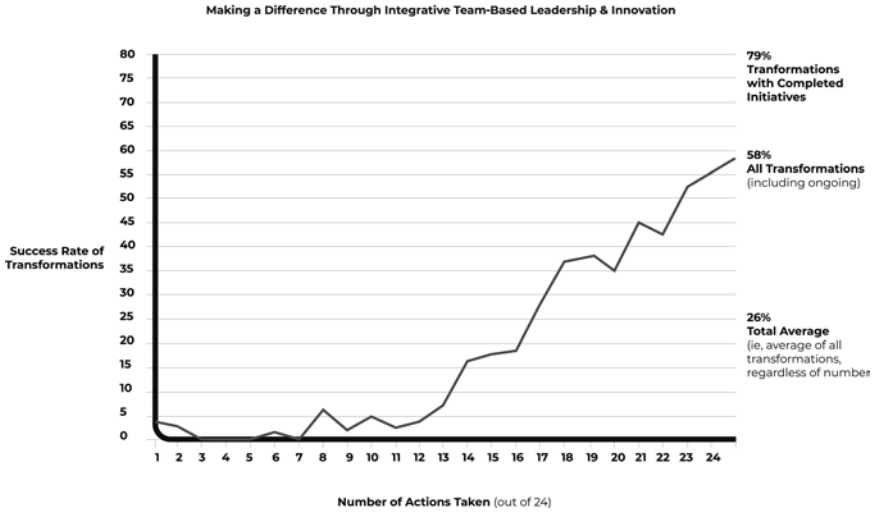

Figure 9.3 How to beat the transformation odds

Source: Adapted from Jacquement, Maor and Reich, 2015

12 (50%) – of those identified, before the success rate really starts to climb. In addition, the researchers highlight those factors that have the greatest impact. Perhaps unsurprisingly, the highest impact factors were associated with different aspects of communication:

- Senior managers communicated openly across the organisation about the transformation's progress and success.
- Senior managers communicated openly across the organisation about the transformation's implications for individuals' day-to-day work.
- Leaders used a consistent change story to align the organisation around the transformation's goals.

The active engagement and visibility of senior leaders to model the behaviours expected of others was particularly important.

One of our interviewees emphasised the need for HoUs to carefully think through the process aspects of the change:

> *If you're not interested in process, you won't make much change. Process is how you effect change. I simplified, unified, regularised and rationalised.*

Another emphasised the HoU's accountability for the change in addition to visibility mentioned earlier:

> *If you are trying to drive increasing levels of engagement and change and culture change, I think you have got to be visible and visibly leading, communicating and* ***being accountable when things don't go to plan****.*
>
> (our emphasis, in boldface)

Does leading change need to change?

In the next chapter, we explore the leadership challenges associated with large-scale crises. Dealing with such an unprecedented and wide-ranging level of change raises the question whether the approach to leading change *itself* needs to change, to take account of different kinds, levels and scales of change. Reframing the concept of change has involved looking at it through a biological lens. For example, what does change look like if conceived in terms of a 'viral' approach?

Over 15 years ago, long before the COVID-19 pandemic, several researchers had been thinking along these lines. Leandro Herrero, in 2006, in his book *Viral Change*,[9] offered some helpful hints. His starting point was to challenge the traditional approach to change, as follows in Table 9.2.

The language and metaphor associated with a viral infection is also captured in a set of 'viral principles', which include the following elements:[10]

- *There is no change unless it is behavioural.*
- *Change behaviours beget culture, not the other way around.*

- *Behaviours sustain processes, not the other way around.*
- *A small set of behaviours has the 'nonlinear' power to create high impact.*
- *A relatively small number of individuals within any organisation have great power in the creation of change. This power is related to various factors such as high connectivity with others, high trust or moral, nonhierarchical authority.*
- *Behaviours endorsed and spread by that small group of individuals within an organisation ('champions') create 'social tipping points', where those new behaviours become established as a norm. 'Critical masses' of individuals adopting those new behaviours are created via imitation and social copying in similar ways as trends or fashions are created in the macro-social arena.*
- *The role of the formal hierarchy, management and leadership, is to support those small groups of highly influential employees who 'infect' the organisation with the changes they have endorsed. It is therefore a role largely backstage or 'invisible'.*

These ideas have been developed in different ways by others as part of a move towards viewing change as a social movement. One particular framework was that described in 2010 by Marshall Ganz,[11] who developed and used his approach to good effect as an adviser to the campaign that led to the election of Barack Obama as US president. More recently, we have also seen the power of such social movements represented in the momentum which followed the tragic death of George Floyd in May 2020. From a small-scale early response, the Black Lives Matter

Table 9.2 Challenging the traditional approach to change

Traditional approach to change	*Viral approach to change*
Mechanistic view of the organisation	Organisms as a model of the organisation
Top-down change and leadership	Multicentric change and distributed leadership, grassroots-like
Hierarchical influence is explicitly or tacitly driven	Peer-to-peer influence more important than hierarchical when it comes to culture
Emphasis on processes ('behaviours are consequences')	Emphasis on behaviours and the behavioural DNA of the organisation – needed to sustain new processes
'Telling people' what to do takes most air time	Selling ideas to people and getting buy-in through peer influence is the real engine
Communication, communication, communication	Infection of ideas and behaviours; social movement
Advocacy at best: 'this is good, follow me'	Activism: 'I am doing X. What about you?'
Formal programme: 'Another corporate initiative' (talk > act)	Well-designed informality: many times silent, often invisible (act > talk)
'Tsunami': everybody involved, massive communication, then hope	'Butterfly': small changes multiplied a thousand times by a champions community
External change experts in every corner	Internal engine of leadership (champions)

movement has continued to build to become, potentially, a significant influence on accelerating changes that had become stalled or that lacked real commitment for action until this point.

Conclusion

The ultimate ambition of any university strategy is to make a difference, to make things better and to have a positive impact on students, staff, stakeholders, society and ultimately the world. Achieving these outcomes requires coordinated action and innovation from many individuals, groups and teams over time. With a clear set of change challenges aligned to your strategy, you have the opportunity to really make an impact. Without an integrative, team-based approach, you may be lucky and make some differences. To really sustain substantive change, we argue, demands more than luck. Long-term success comes much more from getting the right balance across a series of activities of the types that we have discussed, combined with an openness to emergent opportunism and the capacity to take calculated risks when moments arise.

Notes

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